

# CONSCIOUSNESS OF CLASS AND CONSCIOUSNESS OF GENERATION

Graham Murdock and  
Robin McCron

## Youth against Class: The spectre of socialism

Our modern images of youth and adolescence were essentially the creations of the Victorian middle class. Although most of the essential elements had been in existence well before then, it was not until the 1850's that they began to coalesce around the familiar themes of separation and dependence. In common with several other strands of Victorian ideology, the emerging ethos of youth was forged in the 'new' public schools and publicised in the flood of magazines and novels which followed the successful launching of *Boys' Own Magazine* in 1855, and the appearance of *Tom Brown's Schooldays* a year later. At first this new definition of youth was confined to the offspring of the middle classes. In successive decades however, it was increasingly detached from this original social base and generalised into a description of a universal stage of individual maturation, so that by the turn of the century the social norms of the middle class had become enshrined as the 'natural' attributes of youth *per se*<sup>1</sup>. From the outset, this image of youth carried a peculiarly powerful cultural charge and was intimately bound up with the hopes and fears of a middle class struggling to hold its own against threats both at home and abroad.

The growth of German naval power was widely seen as a serious threat to Britain's imperial possessions and to the sea routes on which their security depended, but the disastrous South African war which had revealed both the poor physical condition of the troops and the inefficiency of the military command, had done little to bolster confidence in Britain's ability to hold onto the Empire. In this situation, patriotism and the elevation of the 'National Interest' above the claims of class were at a premium. At the same time, the increasing influence of socialism and the growing strength of organised labour in both the industrial and political spheres promised an intensification rather than a dampening-down of class conflict at home. The British bourgeoisie therefore felt themselves to be threatened on

two sides; by the German enemy without and the socialist enemy within. Consequently, the question of cementing national unity was seen as more or less synonymous with the problem of containing working class militancy.

With the extensions of the franchise in 1867 and 1884, the pivot of containment had shifted away from coercion and towards ideology. In order to preserve the image of the State as a liberal democracy, governed by freedom of choice, strategies of incorporation were obliged to proceed primarily through inducement and persuasion rather than through coercion and force. Repression was not ruled out completely however. During the 1893 strikes for example, miners were shot at Featherstone and gunboats appeared off the Hull docks; a pattern that was to be repeated in 1911, with shootings at Ton-y-pandy and gunboats moored in the Mersey. These periodic shows of state force were the exceptions rather than the rule however. More important was the pervasive and continuous struggle to establish the hegemony of the dominant ideology, a struggle in which attempts to capture the hearts and minds of the rising generation played a key role. From the beginning then, the question of youth and its consciousness was inextricably tied to the issue of class consciousness and class conflict.

The struggle for hegemony over youth centred on the state-sponsored school system established in the wake of the 1870 Act. But for some considerable time the reach of schooling was decidedly limited. Until 1918, when the leaving age was fixed at fourteen, a sizeable section of working class adolescents left before then, thereby evading the schools' influence at what commentators had come to regard as a decisive stage in their mental and moral development. It was largely in an effort to reach these 'escapees' that agencies developed to penetrate and organise the leisure of working class adolescents. They included the Boys' Brigade, the Church Lads' Brigade, the YMCA, and most influential of all, Baden Powell's Boy Scouts.

Behind the preoccupations with health, cleanliness and abstinence, with which scouting is usually associated, lay an over-riding concern with the need to foster class unity in the interests of national and imperial defence. As Baden Powell put it in his best selling handbook of 1908, *Scouting For Boys*:

If a strong enemy wants our rich commerce and dominions, and sees us in Britain divided against each other, he will pounce in and capture them. For this you begin, as boys, not to think of other classes of boys to be your enemies. Remember, whether rich or poor, from castle or from slum, you are all Britons in the first place, and you've got to keep Britain up against outside enemies. (1930: 280).

These exhortations to patriotism and national unity were accompanied by attacks on socialism. "Many people", argued

BP, "get led away by some new politician with some extreme idea ... Extreme ideas are seldom much good ... More thrift rather than a change of government will bring money to all. And a strong united Empire will bring us power, peace and prosperity such as no socialist dream could do" (quoted in Wilkinson, 1969:11). Although the Scouts were easily the largest of the Edwardian Youth organisations, the movement drew most of its members from the middle and lower middle classes, and never managed to capture a broad base of support among working class youth. Nevertheless, there is little doubt that the ethos embodied in scouting and publicised in the magazines and comics for youth permeated popular thinking and helped to create "that mood of sustained patriotism among youth that led to mass volunteering on the outbreak of war in August 1914" (Springhall, 1971: 151). After the armistice however, there was an upsurge of anti-militarism which Baden Powell was quick to accommodate to. Hence in his *Scouting Towards Reconstruction* of 1918, the earlier stress on imperial defence was replaced by calls for international co-operation and brotherhood. At the same time however, the success of the Russian revolution revived the twin spectres of socialism and class war and led BP to renew his appeal for youth to unite against the overtures of Bolshevism:

There are men who, through their orators and their literature, preach class hatred and down with everything ... It is simple mad Bolshevism such as might bring about not merely the downfall of capitalists but the ruin of the great mass of quiet steady-going citizens and wage earners.

(quoted in Wilkinson, 1969: 16)

If the emerging images of youth were permeated with fears of socialism and class conflict, they also carried the middle classes' own doubts about the present state of capitalism. These insecurities were codified and invested with the seal of science in Stanley Hall's seminal text book of 1904, *Adolescence*. According to Hall, individual maturation recapitulated the development of the race and the transition from childhood to maturity corresponded to the leap from barbarism to civilisation. Hence, the future of civilisation hinged on what happened during the crucial intermediate stage of adolescence. The condition of youth therefore provided a yardstick against which the progress or decay of capitalist society could be measured. "Only here," argued Hall "can we hope to find true norms against the tendencies of civilisation generally." (1905: viii) Where Hall led, others quickly followed and built up an image of youth as a force for regeneration and renewal, bearing the torch of idealism and spirituality amidst the encircling gloom of rampant materialism. Here for example is the eminent social reformer, Jane Addams, in full lyrical flight in 1909:

... are we so under the influence of the Zeitgeist that we can detect only commercial values in the young as well as in the old? It is as if our eyes were holden to the mystic beauty, the redemp-

tive joy which young people might supply to our dingy towns.

We may listen to the young voices rising clear above the roar of industrialism and the prudent councils of commerce, or we may become hypnotised by the sudden new emphasis placed upon wealth and power, and forget the supremacy of spiritual forces in men's affairs.

(1972: 9; 161)

This image of youth as a regenerative force gained renewed power from the enthusiasm for reconstruction which followed the armistice of 1918. Youth, it was felt, would bring about a bloodless revolution which would abolish class inequalities and exploitation without class warfare and without socialism. As a newspaper editorial of 1919 put it:

This social revolution that we are launching is not an affair of classes. It has deeper roots. It is the revolt of the Young against the Old ... The victims will be those who have not seen the vision ... rich men who hold on to broad acres, haughty women who distil exotic perfumes from the sweat and toil of the masses they scorn, vulgar profiteers with swollen pockets and swollen bellies ... the half educated, intoxicated agitators who presume to organise and drive the manual workers ...<sup>2</sup>

This current of popular rhetoric found its academic expression in a conservative theory of history of which Ortega y Gasset was the principal exponent.

If the Russian revolution had succeeded, the attempt in Germany had failed; a failure which in Ortega's view marked the "sunset of revolution" in Europe and the death of historical materialism as a plausible theory of social change. "Changes of an industrial or political nature are superficial", he argued, and depend essentially on the complex of ideas embedded in the "vital sensibility" of the age. Moreover, he argued, these "changes in vital sensibility which are decisive in history", appear under the form of a generation, with the result that "The Generation" is "the most important conception in history" and "the pivot responsible for the movement of historical evolution" (1931: 15). In Ortega's schema then, youth replaced the proletariat as the primary subject of history and generational succession superseded the class struggle as the principal engine of change. Apart from vague assertions of "organic capacity" however, Ortega never addressed himself to the vital question of how exactly age groups developed a common consciousness and began to act as a coherent historical force, and it was left to Karl Mannheim to take up this question in his celebrated paper of 1927, "The Problem of Generations".

### Generations, Classes and the Sociologists: the hidden debate

For Mannheim, generational consciousness had its origins in the attitudes and responses developed by particular close-knit "concrete groups" in the course of responding to their shared

social situation. Once formed however, "these attitudes and formative tendencies are," he argues, "capable of being detached from the concrete groups of their origin and of exercising an appeal and binding force "over generation members in similar social situations who "find in them the satisfying expression of their location" (1952: 307). As a result, argues Mannheim, there develops among these 'generation units' of similarly located contemporaries, "an identity of responses, a certain affinity in the way in which all move with and are formed by their common experiences" - in short a shared consciousness. (Ibid: 306). Once crystallised, this 'generation unit' consciousness may broaden its base still further and form the core of a new 'generation style' separate from, and perhaps opposed to, the dominant style of the adult generation. The model Mannheim had in mind here was the *Wandervogel* movement which originated in 1901 among a small group of Berlin adolescents and rapidly gained the support of large numbers of middle class German youths in the years before 1914. But if the *Wandervogel* illustrated Mannheim's thesis, they also indicated its limitations. In particular, the fact that the movement had made little impact on working class youth raised the crucial question of the relationship between generational consciousness and consciousness of class. Mannheim tacitly acknowledged this as a problem and qualified his thesis by pointing out that, "within each generation there can exist a number of differentiated, antagonistic generation-units". (ibid) At the same time however, the basis of these differentiations and antagonisms was never made explicit and the relationship between age and class was consequently left unexplored. Nevertheless, Mannheim's formulation did at least go beyond the very loose sense in which 'generation' had been employed up till then, and began to specify the necessary levels of analysis. Unfortunately these careful distinctions were mostly ignored by subsequent writers.

Mannheim's essay was not translated until the early Fifties, and so for over twenty years it remained virtually unknown among British and American sociologists, and even when it was finally published it went largely unnoticed. The problem it raised however, was not neglected. On the contrary, from the mid-twenties onwards, sociologists on both sides of the Atlantic became increasingly preoccupied with the question of generational consciousness and its relation to social change. This emerging sociological literature tended to work within rather than against the definitions of the situation established by popular commentaries on youth. But there was a significant difference. Whereas most earlier writers had made no secret of the fact that they saw the question of youth and its consciousness as tied to the wider issue of class stratification and class struggle, the sociologists' increasing attachment to notions of 'scientific' methodology and value-freedom led them to conceal or devalue the political dimension of their work. The debate with Marx's ghost, and with the more substantial spectre of organised socialism,

continued of course, but it was conducted surreptitiously. Hence, in much of the mainstream sociological work on youth, until comparatively recently, class has either been evacuated altogether or treated as relatively unimportant.

In the same year that Mannheim's essay came out in Germany, America saw the publication of Frederic Thrasher's influential book *The Gang* (1927), in which he argued that adolescents in downtown Chicago had responded to the social disorganisation of the slum by creating a separate and self contained social network of gangs, sustained by a distinctive culture. The gangs therefore operated in a sort of social no-man's-land which began at the point where conventional institutions had broken down. When Wall Street crashed and the Depression began two years later, there was a general feeling that social disorganisation had broken out of the inner city and become both widespread and endemic. Hence it was scarcely surprising that sociologists should begin to see the breakdown of generational relations and the development of autonomous peer group cultures as features not simply of slum life but of the general state of the nation. But it was left to Parsons in 1942 to suggest that these developing peer group cultures were in fact localised expressions of a more broadly based generational consciousness which was crystallising around a distinctive 'youth culture' centred on hedonistic consumption. Parsons' 'youth culture' was the culture of a generation who consumed without producing - a generation whose lengthening confinement in age-specific educational institutions was seen as removing them, not only from the productive system, but also from the class relations rooted in that system. This emphasis on the increasing centrality of age divisions and the corresponding irrelevance of class inequalities, coupled with stress on consumption and leisure as the pivots of youth consciousness, was destined to dominate the sociology of youth for the next three decades.

After 1945 these themes were amplified and recharged by the widespread assumption that in the post war period the axis of advanced capitalist societies was shifting from work to leisure and that new relations of consumption were rapidly replacing the old relations of production at the centre of social life. The well publicised rise of the 'youth culture' rooted in the leisure styles sponsored by the burgeoning youth-oriented entertainment industry epitomised this shift perfectly. Where the boys' clubs and the Scouts had failed, the Beatles and Mary Quant appeared to be succeeding. The rising generation were in the process of transcending class while preserving capitalism. Nominal equality of access to the new leisure styles seemed to be cancelling out the last remaining vestiges of class inequalities in life chances. Post war youth, the inheritors of affluence, therefore appeared as the vanguard of the coming 'society of leisure', in whose wake marched the 'new' working class with their television sets and bottles of Beaujolais. It was the old vision of renewal without revolution, decked out in the imagery of

advertising.

Although downgraded, class did not disappear completely from the analysis of youth. On the contrary, studies both of the school system and of deviant behaviour repeatedly demonstrated the ways in which the life chances and life styles of working class adolescents were structured by their class location. At the same time however, the issues of educational inequality and juvenile delinquency were increasingly defined as self-contained 'problems' that could be quite adequately understood and dealt with by specialised research and remedial reforms. Consequently, the broader implications of these studies were left largely unexplored, and mainstream writing on youth remained securely wedded to the myth of classlessness.

The vision of youth as the vanguard of social change reached its zenith with the emergence of the 'counter culture' in the late 'sixties. This development took most commentators almost completely by surprise, and in the absence of a coherent class analysis the majority turned towards idealist theories. Charles Reich's, *The Greening of America*, a best-seller on both sides of the Atlantic, typified the dominant train of argument:

Always before, young people felt themselves tied more to their immediate situations than to a 'generation'. But now an entire culture, including music, clothes and drugs, began to distinguish youth. As it did, the message of consciousness went with it.

Consciousness is capable of changing and of destroying the Corporate State, without violence, without seizure of political power, without overthrow of any existing group of people ..... (1972: 189; 253).

Youth it seemed, was in the process of becoming a generation 'for itself' with a distinctive consciousness and style, and the Hippies appeared as an advanced guard, "rehearsing in vivo possible cultural solutions to central life problems posed by the emerging society of the future" - a society of affluence and leisure. (Davis, 1970: 330).

The late 'sixties did mark a turning point, but the significant movement was not an advance towards abundance but a return to austerity. As the economic situation of the advanced capitalist societies worsened, it became increasingly apparent that the key conflicts of the future would not be contestations between generations over modes of consciousness and cultural style, but struggles between classes and class factions over economic resources and basic life chances. But it was not simply a question of dusting off old theories. The complex of social changes that had taken place since the war may not have dissolved the class structure, but they had certainly altered many ways in

which people experienced and coped with it. Consequently, sociologists who acknowledged the centrality of class were presented with the problem of developing an analysis sensitive enough to cope with the complexities of the contemporary situation. This remains our basic task.

Youth presents a particularly difficult problem for analysis. The post war period has seen the final institutionalisation of adolescence through the establishment of universal secondary schooling and the emergence of a whole complex of leisure and entertainment facilities aimed specifically at youth. These agencies have not removed adolescents from the class system as the 'youth culture' theorists maintained, but they have placed youth in a special relationship to that system. Age has therefore become an increasingly important mediation of class (especially for women), structuring both the forms of class experience and the ways in which these experiences are worked through. At the same time, the ideologies which underpin the new institutions of youth - ideologies of equal opportunity, of consumer sovereignty, and above all, of adolescence as a special and uniquely important period - continue to conceal the centrality of class inequalities and to emphasise the primacy of age divisions. Hence the rhetoric of generational separation and youth equality remains very much available, offering an insistent framework for common sense understandings of social structure and social change. As a result, age is important, not only as a mediation of class experience, but also as a mediation of class consciousness.

The relationship between consciousness of generation and consciousness of class therefore constitutes an important topic for investigation. It is important not only because it is indispensable to a reconstituted sociology of youth, but also because it is central to an adequate analysis of how class consciousness comes to be formed, and of how this formation may be blocked or forestalled. At the present time explorations of this relationship have developed in two main directions; the first springs from a revival of interest in Mannheim's schema, and the second from advances in subcultural analysis.

#### Mapping consciousness: Mannheim and beyond

The initial flurry of sociological speculation which greeted the emergence of the 'counter culture' was very quickly followed by a spate of empirical inquiries into the social origins and ideologies of the hippies and communards. These studies confirmed what the more perceptive commentators had realised all along - that the 'counter culture' was essentially a movement of educated middle class youth. This led in turn to a revival of interest in Mannheim's schema, and more particularly in his concept of the 'generation unit'. Hence the 'counter culture' was increasingly



characterised, not as the crystallised consciousness of youth, but as the distinctive 'style' of a particular 'generation unit'.

Not only was Mannheim's schema revived however, it was also extended, as researchers recognised that contemporary youth not only contained "a number of differentiated, antagonistic generation units", but that these divisions were rooted in the wider structure of class inequalities. As two of the 'new' American sociologists of youth recently put it:

A crucial but underdeveloped aspect of generational analysis concerns the importance of class groupings in the development of generation-based issues, and the necessity of examining the way in which superordinate and subordinate class groupings mediate the experience of age-cohort membership.

(Laufer and Bengtson, 1974: 181, our emphasis)

Although these commentators acknowledge the importance of class, they continue to treat age as the primary focus of analysis. Class therefore appears as a secondary variable which is relevant primarily as a mediation of generational experience. Not surprisingly therefore, the empirical work generated by this formulation has by-passed the question of class consciousness and concentrated instead on the extent to which youth in various class locations share the consciousness and style embodied in the 'counter culture'<sup>4</sup>. Even so, this research marks a distinct advance over the recent work of Frank Musgrove, who continues to devalue the importance of class and to insist that the "counter culture is the pervasive spirit of a new generation" (1974a: 35). Recent studies of class consciousness among adolescents are equally lopsided however, in that they ignore the question of generational consciousness completely<sup>5</sup>.

The next step is to move towards a more comprehensive analysis which explores the relationship between consciousness of class and of generation, and the relation of both to adolescents' overall conceptions of social stratification. As a beginning we need detailed mappings of the common sense categories and theories through which adolescents in different class locations describe and explain the stratification system. So far the most consistent and well worked out attempts at mapping everyday understandings of stratification have come from sociologists interested in class consciousness. Consequently, recent work in this area provides a convenient starting point for a critical examination of available methodologies.

In a recent work, Michael Mann has usefully distinguished four levels of class consciousness: identity - the definition of oneself as sharing a particular class location; the perception of the class structure as centred on the permanent opposition between capital and labour; totality - the acceptance of the first two levels as the defining characteristic both of one's own social situation and of the society as a whole; and finally, the vision

of an alternative social order towards which one moves through class struggle (1973: 13). By and large, recent British work on class consciousness has concentrated on the first two levels focussing on people's class identifications and overall images of the class structure.

Nearly all these studies are based on a more or less standard battery of questions asked on a questionnaire or in the course of an interview. At first sight these questions appear to be perfectly straightforward, e.g. "A lot of people talk about the different social classes in Britain. What do you think is meant by the term 'social class'? How many social classes are there?" (Stradling and Zuriek, 1973: 298). Questions like these however, rest on the crucial but untested assumption that respondents have a clear definition of 'class' which forms the basis of a coherent image of the overall class structure. This assumption is highly problematic.

Recent studies, including our own ongoing research, have indicated that conceptions of class are tangential or irrelevant to a number of people's understanding of stratification. This does not mean that they are not aware of deep-seated social divisions and antagonisms, but simply that this awareness has not crystallised around the notion of class. For, as two British sociologists have recently reminded us the "feelings of subordination, discrimination, unfairness and hostility which are the essence of class opposition ... can arise in a number of sectors of social life and be expressed in terms in which the word 'class' is never used" (Moorhouse and Chamberlain, 1974: 390). This is not a particularly startling or new perception. It has been grasped by countless social workers and teachers confronted with the hostility of their working class charges. As one harassed master at a ragged school in Victorian London put it:

... here the very appearance of one's coat is to them the badge of class - for although they may not know the meaning of the word, they know very well, or at least feel, that we are the representatives of beings with whom they have ever considered themselves at war.

(quoted in Carpenter, 1968: 60)

The ethnomethodologists may be correct in claiming that everyone in their own way is a sociologist, but this does not mean that everyone thinks and speaks like a sociologist. Consequently, we cannot take it for granted that class constitutes a central category in people's everyday vocabulary. On the contrary, how far this is the case is a matter for empirical investigation, and we must pay particular attention to cases where class situations are described in other terms. We need in fact to restore the category of "false consciousness" to the centre of analysis.

Even where the term 'class' is used however, it may take on resonances which evade the standard sociological classifications.

A recent Australian study for example found that a sizeable number of respondents saw class primarily in terms of a division between people who were snobbish and kept themselves aloof, and people who mixed in easily with a wide range of social groups (Hillier, 1975). Now it may be, as the author himself suggests, that snobbishness is a particularly resonant concept among Australians, but it also crops up quite frequently in the British context, as in this extract from *The Paint House*:

... when I was at school I thought I was middle class ya know. So I said to me mum 'we're middle class' and she said 'You fucking ain't ya know; middle class is snobs.' And I didn't know. I thought because you wasn't a tramp you was middle class. I thought this because there was always people at school poorer than you ... so you might be 'igher.

(Daniel and McGuire, eds. 1972: 73)

These sorts of localised conceptions of class are in fact the rule rather than the exception, for as David Lockwood has so eloquently pointed out:

For the most part men visualise the class structure ... of their society from the vantage points of their own particular milieux, and their perceptions of the larger society will vary according to their experiences of social inequality in the smaller societies in which they live out their daily lives.

(1966: 249)

A detailed awareness of concrete social contexts is therefore essential to an adequate analysis of social consciousness. This means going well beyond crude indicators of class location and examining the ways in which the class structure is actually experienced and understood at the level of everyday life.

At the same time however, it is important not to lose sight of the fact that localised conceptions of class are developed within the overall framework provided by the hegemonic ideology. They are consequently the products not only of people's persistent efforts to impose meaning on their own immediate experience of inequality and subordination, but also of their attempts to appropriate and rework the definitions of the situation offered by mass communications and education systems. The characteristic outcome is an uneasy amalgam of extrapolations from personal experience and elements derived from the dominant ideology<sup>7</sup>. In fact, "a social situation which gives rise to a coherent image of society may well be the exception rather than the rule" (Cousins and Brown, 1972: 3). Consequently, studies which gloss over these inconsistencies inevitably conceal the complexity of social consciousness.

Disjunctions and contradictions in class consciousness are likely to be particularly characteristic of adolescents, precisely because they are enmeshed in institutions which explicitly devalue and disguise the centrality of class inequalities, and offer an alternative conception which emphasises the importance of age differences. What impact this insistent celebration of youth

has on adolescents' consciousness of class, remains a key topic for future investigation. The recent work of people like Richard Brown, Jim Cousins, and Theo Nichols suggests that, sensitively handled, interviews and eavesdropping still have a great deal to offer. But even at their best these techniques have a major drawback. Because they concentrate exclusively on verbalisations of consciousness, they ignore the ways in which social consciousness is objectified and expressed through other forms of social and cultural action<sup>8</sup>. Eventually then, it is necessary for analysis to "go beyond particular everyday conceptions ... and to show the consequences of these formulations and their application in action" (Hillier, 1975: 22). The attempt to develop such an analysis has formed one of the main trajectories of recent research on youth subcultures, including the work of the Birmingham Centre.

### Reading Style: directions in subcultural analysis

The particular version of subcultural analysis we are concerned with here focusses on the way in which the shared social experiences of adolescents in particular class locations are collectively expressed and negotiated through the construction of distinctive leisure styles. Subcultural styles are made up of an amalgam of elements drawn from two main sources - the 'situated' class cultures embedded in the family and the local neighbourhood, and the 'mediated' symbol systems sponsored by the youth orientated sectors of the entertainment industry. These elements are not taken over raw, however. On the contrary, subcultural styles are the product of a cumulative process of *selection* and *transformation* through which available objects, symbols and activities, are removed from their normal social context, stripped of some or all of their conventional connotations and reworked "by members of the group into a new and coherent whole with its own special significance" (Clarke and Jefferson, 1974: 15). A central part of this process involves appropriating the ostensibly classless artefacts and commodities of the 'teenage culture' industry and investing them with class-based meanings and resonances. Subcultural styles can therefore be seen as coded expressions of class consciousness transposed into the specific context of youth and reflective of the complex way in which age acts as a mediation both of class experience and of class consciousness.

Since subcultural styles are coded expressions of consciousness, the primary act of analysis is an act of decoding. Hence, "reading" the style, in the sense of uncovering the meanings attached to its constituent elements and to the relations between them is seen as providing a method for mapping the class consciousness of youth as a complex and contextualised whole. Through his sensitive and elaborate "reading" of the style supported by a group of working class boys in north Paris for example, Jean Monod (1967) is able to present a finely textured account of their

underlying conceptions of social stratification. But to date, the most comprehensive attempts at "reading" style have come from English research on working class youth, most notably Phil Cohen's pioneering account of East End subcultures (1972) and the subsequent work conducted at the Birmingham Centre on the style of the Teds, Mods, and Skinheads<sup>9</sup>. Taken together, these studies offer an original approach to the relations between class, age and consciousness, which no-one seriously interested in the possibilities of developing a more adequate sociology of contemporary youth can afford to ignore. At the same time however, the approach presented in these studies is subject to several important limitations.

Contemporary subcultural analysis has its roots in delinquency research and still reflects the preoccupations of that area. Hence, recent research continues to follow earlier work in focussing on the deviant rather than the conventional, on working class adolescents rather than those from the intermediate and middle classes, and most crucial of all, on boys rather than girls. As a result of these imbalances and lacunae, the range of recent studies remains relatively restricted. The neglect of adults is another significant gap in the available literature.

In contrast to the 'youth culture' theorists' simplistic insistence on the growing 'gap' between the generations, the proponents of subcultural analysis follow David Matza (1961 and Matza and Sykes, 1961) in stressing the complex patterns of continuity and disjunction between youth subcultures and the adults' cultures in which they are embedded. Phil Cohen for example, argues that "the latent function of subculture is ... to express and resolve, albeit 'magically', the contradictions which remain hidden or unresolved in the parent culture" (1972: 23). Similarly, John Clarke and his collaborators suggest "that the skinheads may be 'read' as an attempt to revive a culture which was changing and entering into new negotiations of its own with the dominant culture as a response to its changed structural position" (1974: 155). Despite the theoretical importance assigned to parental cultures in these studies, they do not examine them empirically, and consequently the crucial cultural relations between the generations are left largely at the level of assertion. The next step therefore, is to move towards a more symmetrical analysis, that takes adolescents and adults in the same basic class locations and examines in detail the correspondences and variations in their respective patterns of class experience, class consciousness and cultural action. Such an analysis is indispensable if we are to arrive at a more adequate and 'grounded' understanding of the way in which age position acts as a mediation of class location.

Subcultural studies are based on the very reasonable assumption that since adolescents' options for action are likely to be fairly

restricted within the work situation, their responses to their class location will be most fully articulated in the spheres of consumption and leisure. By and large, this assumption is borne out by the available evidence. At the same time however, this emphasis on the importance of leisure has led researchers to concentrate almost all their effort in this area and to pay relatively little attention to adolescents' work experiences. This has produced the paradoxical situation in which an approach, which explicitly sets out to trace the links between class location and social consciousness, lacks an adequate analysis of the most powerful and insistent mediation of class position - the work situation. Without a detailed grasp of the ways in which class inequalities are experienced and negotiated at the point of production however, any attempt to relate particular forms of consciousness and cultural response to particular class locations must necessarily remain partial.

Clearly, filling these gaps is an obvious priority for future research, but it is not just a matter of adding more studies. There are also important problems of method to be confronted and worked through.

Subcultural studies start by taking distinctive subcultural styles and the groups who are involved in them, and then working backwards to uncover their class base. The result is an elegant and eminently plausible account of the homologous relation between cultural styles and structural situations. If this procedure is reversed however, and the analysis starts from the class location rather than from the cultural response, a serious problem presents itself, as it soon becomes apparent that the same structural location can generate and sustain a variety of responses and modes of accommodation.

Recent studies of working class areas for example, suggest that several distinct youth subcultures can coexist within the same locality, each drawing its bearers and supporters from boys in essentially the same class situation. Stephen Buff's Chicago research (1970), for instance, showed that while most of the boys in the area supported the dominant 'greaser' style, a significant minority had gravitated towards the 'hippie' style generated from within the middle class. Peter Willmott (1969) found a similar group of class 'defectors' among his Bethnal Green boys in the mid-sixties. The problem therefore, is not only to explain why styles like the Teds, Greasers, and Skinheads develop among particular groups of working class youth at particular points in time, but also to explain why adolescents sharing the same class location should be attracted to styles developed by other class factions. To explain these subtle variations in subcultural affiliations and underlying consciousness, we need to go some way beyond the relatively crude indicators of class position

that are often used - parental occupation, school position etc. - and examine the concrete mediations through which class inequalities are actually experienced and comprehended at the level of everyday life.

The Willmott and Buff studies also raise another problem for subcultural analysis, and one which we have become increasingly aware of in the course of our own recent research in Leicester. This is the question of 'conventional' youth.

Subcultural theory originally provided one of the main theoretical planks of the study. Consequently, we started out expecting subcultural styles to provide the dominant channel through which adolescents articulated their definitions of themselves and their social situation, an expectation which seemed to be supported by the results of an early pilot study (Murdock and McCron, 1973). As the main fieldwork phase got under way however, it became increasingly clear that a number of respondents were not involved in any of the available subcultures in the town. Instead they tended to orientate themselves around the styles sponsored by official youth agencies or by the mainstream teenage entertainment industry. In contrast to subcultural formations, these styles were not re-made or adapted to any great extent, but were taken over more or less intact. Far from challenging or opposing the dominant meaning system they were in fact expressions and extensions of it. A comprehensive analysis of youth however, must necessarily be capable of accommodating and explaining not only deviancy and refusal but also convention and compliance By definition however, subcultures can only exist underneath the dominant culture; they cannot exist within it, and consequently subcultural analysis cannot cope with 'conventional' youth styles. This is not an argument for jettisoning subcultural analysis, but it is an argument for recognising its limitations.

### Conclusion

At the present time then, the complex and subtle interplay between class location, age position and social consciousness has begun to attract the attention of sociologists on both sides of the Atlantic, and has so far generated several distinct and largely self contained lines of analysis. But if the available studies have not yet resulted in a coherent and unified approach to the area, they have at least indicated, if only by default, what such an approach entails.

Firstly, it must be *comprehensive* and include those youth groups which have been ignored or relegated to the periphery of available accounts. Secondly, it must be *symmetrical* and deal not simply with adolescents but also with adults, and with the relations between the two. Thirdly, it must be rooted in a detailed empirical examination of the concrete work and non-work

contexts through which class inequalities are actually mediated into everyday experience. At the same time however, it must also be able to show how the forms of consciousness and action generated within these contexts are embedded in, and shaped by, more general structural and ideological formations. This requires a *structural and historical analysis of the relations between shifts in the social and cultural position of youth and changes in the structure of class relations and class-based meaning systems*. Without this more macro level of analysis, the approach's explanatory power will be severely curtailed. Consequently, developing conceptual and empirical linkages between specific instances and general social and cultural processes presents a central problem. But it is a problem that must be confronted and coped with, for ultimately the adequacy of the approach sketched here hinges on its capacity to illuminate the relations between biography and history. Clearly such an approach cannot be erected on the basis of any single methodology. Indeed, making a fetish of particular procedures and empirical techniques is just about the quickest way to bankrupt a promising line of analysis. Providing their limitations are recognised and allowed for, subcultural analysis, sensitive interviewing, and the 'new' social history, all have something distinctive to contribute

Reconstructing the sociology of youth along the lines outlined here is not going to be easy, but we would argue that it is worth the effort. It is important not only because it holds out the promise of a more comprehensive analysis of present-day youth, but also because it is indispensable to a more adequate understanding of the formation of class consciousness and the dynamics of "false" consciousness in modern Britain. Just as earlier images of youth were haunted by the spectre of socialism, so contemporary socialism is haunted by the dominant mythology of generations. Demystification is therefore a necessary step towards exorcism.

### FOOTNOTES

1. The 'democratisation' of adolescence is illuminatingly analysed in Chapter 3 of John R. Gillis (1974).
2. 'Collum', 'The New England: Social Transformation to be led by Young Men Back from the War', *Daily Chronicle* (Monday, June 16th 1919: 4).
3. The problematic place of class in mainstream American and British work on youth is discussed more fully in: Graham Murdock, forthcoming.
4. See, for example: Patricia Kasschau, Edward Ransford and Vern Bengtson (1974).
5. See also: Frank Musgrove (1974b).
6. See, for example: Robert Stradling and Elia Zuriek (1973).
7. This point is illuminatingly discussed in: Theo Nichols (1974).
8. For a perceptive discussion of the limitations of techniques which rely on verbalisations, see: Paul Willis (1974).
9. See, for example: John Clarke, Dick Hebdige and Tony Jefferson (1974).